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GIR OFFICIALS
AND FORENSIC
EXPERTS GET
TO WORK AT
THE SCENE OF
THE CRIME

Science in THE WILD

Forensic evidence and DNA fingerprinting helps nab 30 Baheliya tribals for poaching 10 lions in Gir National Park



| By Mihir Srivastava |

Between February and March 2007, 10 lions were killed by poachers in three different incidents at the Gir National Park (GNP) which houses 360 Asiatic lions, the only surviving population in the wild. Eighteen months later, 30 tribals belonging to the Baheliya tribe were found guilty by a local court in Junagadh and sentenced to three years imprisonment. This is unprecedented in the history of wildlife crime

in India on two counts: use of forensics to crack the case and speedy conviction of the accused.

In late March 2007, Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi took personal interest in the case and the investigation was handed over from the Forest Department to the CID-crime under Inspector General of Police (IGP) Keshav Kumar. "We inherited a blind case with no seizure, no eyewitnesses," says Kumar. Forensics was the only ray of hope. The Modi Government gave him a seven-member

team along with a mobile forensic lab. The reconstruction of the site of crime, linking the evidence gathered to the perpetrators of the crime was crucial for solving the case. Each and every piece of evidence was meticulously collected and sealed. Evidence collected from the scene indicated that the poachers were in the forest along with their families.

At this stage of investigations crucial help came from a Delhi-based NGO, Wildlife Protection Society of India (WPSI), which specialises in anti-